



Guinea

Located on the west coast of Africa, Guinea became the first French colony in Africa to gain independence, in 1958.

The country was under military rule from 1984 to 1995.



GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plains and mangrove swamps in west rise to forested or savanna highlands in the south. Semidesert in the north.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with a wet season April–October. Conakry is especially rainy. Hot, dry *harmattan* wind blows from Sahara during dry season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Peul and Malinké make up most of the population, but rivalries between them have allowed coastal peoples such as the Soussou to dominate politics. Daily life revolves around the extended family. Women acquired influence under Marxist party rule between 1958 and 1984, but the Muslim revival since then has reversed the trend. Private enterprise has created a business class.



THE ECONOMY

Substantial gold, diamond, and especially bauxite reserves. Cash crops: bananas, coffee, pineapples, palm oil. Poor infrastructure. Instability.



INSIGHT: The colors of Guinea's flag represent the three words of the country's motto: work (red), justice (yellow), and solidarity (green)



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Guinea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1958

CAPITAL: Conakry

POPULATION: 10.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 94,925 sq. miles
(245,857 sq. km)

DENSITY: 106 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Pulaar, Malinké, Soussou, French*

RELIGIONS: Muslim 65%, traditional beliefs 33%, Christian 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Peul 39%, Malinké 23%, other 21%, Soussou 11%, Kissi 6%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Guinea franc = 100 centimes